

Westminster Walk (Kids)

UK Family Tour

Big Ben: The Most Famous Bong in the World

B Surprise: Big Ben isn't the tower. It isn't even the clock. Big Ben is the bell — a giant, thirteen-and-a-half-tonne bell hanging at the top of what's officially called the Elizabeth Tower. The bell weighs as much as two African elephants, and its deep BONG has marked the hours since 1859. Listen carefully if it strikes while you're here: the note is slightly off, because Big Ben is cracked. The first bell cracked during testing before it was even installed. They melted it down and made a new one — which also cracked, two months after it started ringing, because someone used a hammer twice as heavy as the rules allowed. Instead of replacing it again, engineers just turned the bell slightly so the hammer hits a different spot, gave it a lighter hammer, and let it ring, crack and all. That slightly imperfect bong is the sound the whole world knows. The clock is famous for almost never being wrong. The clockmakers fine-tune it in the most low-tech way imaginable: a small stack of old pennies sits on the pendulum, and adding or removing one penny changes the clock's speed by two-fifths of a second per day. The most famous clock on Earth, adjusted with pocket change.

The Bell That Crossed the Bridge

Where did this giant bell come from? It was born in a famous workshop in the east of London called the Whitechapel Bell Foundry, the oldest factory in the whole of Britain. It made bells for more than four hundred years before it finally closed in 2017. And here is a wonderful coincidence: the very same workshop cast another world-famous cracked bell, the Liberty Bell in America. So the two most famous cracked bells on Earth are cousins, made in the same little corner of London.

To make Big Ben, the founders melted copper and tin together into a glowing orange river of metal, hotter than a volcano, and poured it into an enormous mould shaped like an upside-down cup. Remember, the very first bell they cast for the tower had already cracked, so this second bell had to travel all the way across London to reach Westminster. Picture it: a bell taller than a grown-up, lying on its side on a special open carriage, pulled slowly through the streets by

sixteen horses wearing ribbons, while crowds lined the road to cheer and wave.

When the bell finally reached the tower, there was no crane like the ones you see today. So how do you lift something that weighs as much as two elephants up into a tower? The workers hauled it straight up the inside, turned on its side, using ropes and muscle, moving it only a little at a time, for about thirty hours. Imagine standing at the bottom and looking up at that vast bell creeping higher and higher above your head, knowing that if a single rope snapped there would be an awful lot of running.

Once it was hung and struck for the first time, its deep BONG rolled out for miles across Victorian London, a city with no cars, no engines, and no sirens to drown it out. For millions of people it slowly became the sound of home. And here is a thought to keep: the metal ringing in the tower above you right now is more than a hundred and sixty years old, and every single hour it still does the exact job it was made to do.

A Secret Light and Four Giant Clocks

Look up at the very top of the tower, above the clock, and find the little lantern-shaped point right at the peak. That is a secret signal called the Ayrton Light, and it has a job most people never notice. Whenever Parliament is working late into the night, that light switches on and glows in the dark. It was put there way back in 1885, and the story goes that Queen Victoria wanted it so that she could look out from Buckingham Palace, across the park, and know at a glance whether her politicians were still up working or had all gone home to bed. So the next time you are near Westminster after dark, glance up. If that little light is shining, it means that inside the building below, grown-ups are still arguing about the laws of the country.

Now look at the clock faces themselves. There are four of them, one facing each direction, so that no matter where you stand in this part of London, a clock is watching you. They are huge. Each face is about seven metres across, taller than two grown-ups standing on each other's shoulders. The big hands that count the minutes are longer than a car.

And here is a detail almost nobody spots: each clock face is not one sheet of glass but hundreds of small pieces of milky white glass, fitted together like a jigsaw puzzle, so that when the lights glow behind them at night the whole face shines.

There is a hidden message on the tower too, written in Latin, curling underneath the clocks. It says, in old-fashioned words, "O Lord, keep safe our Queen Victoria the First." It is a little prayer, carved for the queen who was on the throne when the tower was built, and it has quietly watched over Westminster ever since, in a language most people walking past can no longer read.

So this is not just a clock. It is a lighthouse for politicians, a jigsaw of glowing glass, and a secret prayer in stone, all wrapped around the most famous bell in the world. Not bad for something you might have walked straight past.

The Great Clean-Up

Not long ago, this tower disappeared. If you had come here between 2017 and 2022, you would not have seen the beautiful stonework at all, because the whole tower, all ninety-six metres of it, was wrapped head to toe in metal scaffolding, like a giant in a cage. It was the biggest repair the tower had ever had, and it took five years.

Here is the tricky part. You cannot simply switch off the most famous clock in the world, because people all over the country still set their day by it. So the engineers did something clever. They kept just one of the four clock faces working, driven by a small electric motor, while they carefully took the other three to pieces. That way, from at least one direction, Big Ben could still tell London the time all through the years of work.

Then they did something even braver. They took the entire Great Clock apart, every single cog and spring and wheel, more than a thousand pieces, laid them out, cleaned them, mended them, and put the whole machine back together again like the world's most serious jigsaw. And while workers were up close cleaning the clock faces, they made a surprise discovery. Under layers of black paint they found the clock's original colours from Victorian times, a deep, rich blue. The tower you see today has been painted back to those first colours, blue and gold, exactly as people saw it when Big Ben was brand new.

They cleaned every stone, replaced hundreds of broken pieces, added tiny lifts and safety features, and gave the clock hands a fresh coat of gleaming gold. It cost an enormous amount of money and caused a lot of grumbling, the way big repairs always do. But in 2022 the scaffolding finally

came down, the bongs came back, and the tower stepped out looking better than it had in a lifetime.

So when you look up now, you are seeing something rare: a very old thing that has just been made new again. The blue you see, the gold that glints, the clean pale stone, that is the tower waking up after its longest sleep, ready to ring out over London for another hundred years and more.

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The Houses of Parliament and the Gunpowder Plot

This huge golden building along the river is the Palace of Westminster, where Britain's laws are made — and where the most famous failed crime in British history almost happened. In 1605, a group of plotters rented a cellar directly underneath the House of Lords and packed it with thirty-six barrels of gunpowder. Their plan: blow up the King and all of Parliament in one blast on the fifth of November. The night before, guards searched the cellars and found a man named Guy Fawkes standing watch over the barrels, with fuses in his pocket. His excuse was not great. The plot failed, and to this day, every fifth of November, Britain celebrates Bonfire Night with fireworks. And here's the wonderful part: every year, before the King comes to open Parliament, the Yeomen of the Guard still ceremonially search the cellars with lanterns — just in case. They've never found anything since. One more thing: most of what you see isn't actually medieval. In 1834 the old palace burned down in a spectacular fire, and this fairy-tale Gothic building replaced it. But Westminster Hall, at its heart, survived — it's over nine hundred years old, with a wooden roof so huge people couldn't figure out how it stayed up.

The Hall That Beat the Fire

Tucked inside this enormous building is one room far, far older than all the rest, a room that has quietly watched almost a thousand years of English history. It is called Westminster Hall, and it was begun in 1097 for a king with a wonderful name, William Rufus, which meant William the Red, probably because of his red face or red hair. When it was built it was one of the largest halls in the whole of Europe, and the king reportedly complained that it was too small, that it was a mere bedroom compared to what he had wanted.

Look up, in your imagination, at its roof. About seven hundred years ago, master carpenters built a wooden roof over the hall so wide and so clever that it needs no pillars down the middle to hold it up. It seems to float. It is the largest medieval wooden roof in northern Europe, and

carved along it are rows of angels with outstretched wings, watching everyone below. Builders and engineers still travel from all over the world just to stare up at it and wonder how it stays there.

This hall has seen astonishing things. Kings held roaring feasts here after their coronations. And in this very room, some of the most famous trials in history took place, including the trial of Guy Fawkes himself, the gunpowder plotter, and even the trial of a king, Charles the First, who was sentenced to death right here under those wooden angels.

Now here is the amazing part for our walk. Remember the great fire of 1834 that burned down almost the whole palace? And the bombs that fell in the Second World War? Somehow, again and again, Westminster Hall survived. Firefighters once had to choose which part of the building to save, and they chose the hall, and they saved it.

And in 2022, when Queen Elizabeth the Second died, her coffin lay here in Westminster Hall so that people could come and say goodbye. So many came that the line of people, waiting quietly day and night, stretched for miles along the river. They walked through this ancient room, under the floating roof and the carved angels, one by one, in a hall that has been welcoming the people of England for nearly a thousand years.

Green Benches, Red Benches, and a Golden Stick

Inside this building there are two big rooms where the arguing happens, and here is a fun way to tell them apart: one is green and one is red. The House of Commons, where the members that ordinary people vote for sit, has green benches. The House of Lords, the grander room, has red benches. So if you ever see politicians on the news in Britain, you can play a game: green seats mean you are watching the Commons, red seats mean you are watching the Lords. Nobody is quite sure why those exact colours were chosen hundreds of years ago, but green and red they have stayed.

Now, the benches are surprisingly small. On busy days there are not enough seats for everyone, so members have to squash together or stand at the doorways. That is on purpose. People decided long ago that a crowded, buzzing room feels more exciting and important than a half-empty one, so they kept it deliberately snug.

Here is my favourite rule of all. In the middle of the Commons sits a heavy golden stick called the mace. It looks like something a giant would use as a club, all gold and jewels. And believe it or not, the whole of Parliament cannot make a single law unless that golden stick is sitting in its place. No

mace on the table, no laws, no arguing, nothing. It is carried in and out with great ceremony every day. Once, a furious politician actually grabbed the mace and tried to march off with it in protest, and it caused an enormous scandal.

And once a year the King himself comes to open Parliament, in a golden carriage, wearing a crown. But the crown is so precious and so important that on some occasions it travels in its very own separate carriage, riding along like a passenger, with people bowing to it as if it were royalty all by itself. Imagine a hat so grand it gets its own car.

So this building is full of these gloriously serious games: green rooms and red rooms, a magic golden stick, and a crown important enough to ride alone. Grown-ups made every one of these rules on purpose, and they follow them, very solemnly, to this day.

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Pelicans, Lions and a One-Armed Hero

Two animal stops now. First, St James's Park, the oldest royal park in London, home to one of the city's oddest traditions: pelicans. Huge white pelicans have lived here since 1664, when the Russian ambassador gave some to King Charles the Second as a present, and ambassadors have kept topping up the flock ever since. They get fresh fish every afternoon, but they freelance too — one pelican became world-famous when tourists filmed it calmly swallowing a whole pigeon. The pelicans like to sit on the benches next to people, completely unbothered. Then, Trafalgar Square, guarded by four gigantic bronze lions. They were sculpted by Sir Edwin Landseer, a painter who had never sculpted before — it took him so long that people wrote jokes about it in the newspapers, and the lions arrived nine years late. Look closely: their backs are the wrong shape, because real lions can't lie belly-down with a straight back like a dog, but Landseer's lion model reportedly wasn't very cooperative. Climbing on the lions is a London tradition. High above them, on a column fifty-two meters tall, stands Admiral Nelson — the one-armed, one-eyed sailor whose coat with the bullet hole you saw in Greenwich. The square is named after his greatest victory: Trafalgar.

Duck Island and the Pelican's Amazing Pouch

Look across the lake here in St James's Park and you will see a little wild island covered in trees and reeds. It is called Duck Island, and it is a secret bird city right in the middle of London. People are not allowed to go there. It belongs entirely to the birds, hundreds of them, ducks and geese and herons and of course the famous pelicans, all nesting and

squabbling and raising their babies just a few steps from one of the busiest cities on Earth. There is even a pretty little cottage at the edge of the island where, long ago, a birdkeeper lived, and a real birdkeeper still looks after all these creatures today.

Now, about that pelican's beak. Have you noticed the stretchy bag of skin hanging under its long beak? That pouch is one of the most amazing tools in the whole animal kingdom. A pelican does not spear fish or chew them. Instead it opens its enormous beak underwater and scoops, like a fishing net made of skin, catching fish and water all together. Then it tips its head, lets the water drain out of the sides, and swallows the fish whole. That pouch can hold more water than its own stomach, gallons of it, far more than you could drink in a day.

There is a funny old poem about exactly this. It goes: "A wonderful bird is the pelican, his beak can hold more than his belly can." And it is completely true. That is why a hungry pelican here once managed to swallow a whole pigeon, feathers and all, because if it fits in the net, down it goes.

Watch how calm they are. Pelicans here will waddle right up beside people and flop down on a bench as if they own it, which, honestly, they sort of do. They have lived in this park for far longer than any person you will ever meet, longer than your grandparents, longer than their grandparents, all the way back to a gift from a faraway ambassador hundreds of years ago. So say a polite hello. You are the visitor here. The pelicans are the locals, and they know it.

Dinner on Top of a Column

Look all the way up Nelson's Column, past the lions, past the stone, to the tiny figure of the admiral standing right at the top. Now imagine having your dinner up there. Because that actually happened. In 1843, just before Nelson's statue was lifted into place, a group of workmen and a few brave gentlemen climbed all the way up and ate a proper dinner on the flat platform at the very top, more than fifty metres in the air, where the statue was about to stand. Fourteen people, a table, and a meal, balanced in the sky above London. After that day, no one has ever stood up there again except Nelson himself, in stone, for more than a hundred and eighty years.

Down at the bottom of the column, look at the four big bronze pictures on each side. Each one shows a different great sea battle that Nelson fought, frozen forever in metal, with tiny sailors and cannons and smoke. And here is a

fierce detail: those bronze pictures were made by melting down real cannons captured from enemy ships. So the panels telling the story of the battles are made from the very weapons of the battles themselves.

Now for a tiny treasure hunt. Walk to the southeast corner of the square and look for what seems to be an ordinary round stone lamp-post. It is not ordinary at all. It is hollow, and inside is just enough room for one person to stand. Long ago it was used as possibly the smallest police station in Britain, a secret lookout where an officer could keep an eye on the crowds and quickly telephone for help if trouble started. People walk past it every single day without ever knowing.

And do not miss the fountains. On a hot day they sparkle and splash, and they were partly designed for a sneaky reason: to fill up space in the square so that huge crowds would have less room to gather during protests. Clever, and beautiful too. So this square hides a rooftop dinner story, pictures made of captured cannon, a police station in a lamp-post, and fountains with a secret job, all guarded by four giant lions who have never told a soul.

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The Church Where Kings Are Crowned

Look up at Westminster Abbey, this huge stone building with pointed towers and windows shaped like arrows pointing at the sky. It is nearly a thousand years old, and it holds a world record you can't see from the outside. Every English and British king and queen since the year 1066 has been crowned right here, on the same spot, in front of the high altar. That's William the Conqueror all the way to King Charles the Third. Kings and queens get married here too. In 2011 a prince named William married Catherine in this abbey, and around two billion people watched on television around the world. Inside, under the stone floor and along the walls, more than three thousand people are buried, including seventeen kings and queens. There are poets and scientists here as well. Imagine the most famous scientist in Britain, Isaac Newton, the man who figured out gravity, lying under a grand marble monument, and near him the ashes of Stephen Hawking, placed here in 2018. And near the great front door there is one grave that everybody, even the king, must walk around instead of over, the grave of a single unknown soldier. We'll come back to all of them. For now, just look at those towers, and picture a thousand years of crowns being lowered onto a thousand years of heads, all in this one spot.

The Oldest Chair in the Kingdom

Inside the abbey stands a wooden chair that doesn't look like much. The paint is worn, the wood is scratched, and if you found it in someone's attic you might throw it away. But this is one of the most important chairs on Earth. It is called the Coronation Chair, and it was built more than seven hundred years ago, around the year 1300, for a king called Edward the First. Almost every king and queen of England since then has sat in this exact chair at the moment the crown was placed on their head. King Charles the Third sat in it in 2023.

Here is the strange part. For hundreds of years, a heavy lump of ancient rock sat on a shelf underneath the seat. It is called the Stone of Scone, and Scottish kings had been crowned on it for centuries, until Edward the First carried it off from Scotland as a prize and shoved it under his English chair, as if to say, I own this now. The Scots wanted it back for seven hundred years. On Christmas morning in 1950, four Scottish students actually broke into the abbey and stole the stone, accidentally snapping it in two. It turned up months later, repaired, and was returned. Finally, in 1996, Britain gave the stone back to Scotland for good, with one promise. It travels back down to London whenever there is a coronation, so the tradition can carry on.

Now look closely at the chair itself, if you get the chance. It is covered in graffiti. Over the centuries, schoolboys and visitors carved their names and initials right into the wood, and nobody stopped them. One carving reportedly brags that a boy slept a whole night in the chair. Somebody actually spent a night snoozing in the most royal chair in the country and then bragged about it by scratching it into the seat. So this battered, scribbled-on, stolen-stone chair is where the crowning happens. Not a golden throne. A worn wooden chair, with a captured stone underneath and children's names carved all over it. Kings and queens have sat here for over seven centuries, and when Charles was crowned, so did he.

Two Enemy Queens in One Grave

Inside the abbey there is a tomb with a marble queen lying on top, and it holds a secret that would have horrified the woman inside. In one grave lie two half-sisters who could not stand each other, Queen Elizabeth the First and Queen Mary the First. Mary was Catholic and burned Protestants. Elizabeth was Protestant and locked Mary's friends away. In life they were rivals, and each of them spent time as a prisoner. But when they died, they were buried in the same

tomb, one on top of the other, and someone carved a message in Latin that means, roughly, partners both in throne and grave, here we sleep in the hope of rising again. Two enemies, stuck together forever.

Nearby is an even sadder story. Elizabeth the First had a cousin, Mary Queen of Scots, and Elizabeth had her executed, her head cut off after nearly twenty years locked up. Yet years later Mary's own son became king of England, and one of the first things he did was build his mother a magnificent tomb in this abbey, grander even than Elizabeth's, as if to say, my mother wins in the end. So the two cousins who were enemies in life now lie in the same church, just a short walk apart, forever.

Then walk into the most beautiful room of all, the Lady Chapel built by King Henry the Seventh. Tip your head back and look up at the ceiling. It is made of solid stone, but it doesn't look like stone. It looks like lace, or the inside of a seashell, or hundreds of frozen fountains spraying out and meeting overhead. This is called fan vaulting, and it is some of the finest ever made anywhere. Every one of those delicate stone ribs is helping to hold up a heavy roof, and it has done so for over five hundred years without falling. The stonemasons who carved it never saw a photograph of it finished, never used a computer, and got it perfectly, impossibly right, all by hand and by eye. Kings, queens, sisters, cousins, enemies and friends, all sleeping under a ceiling that looks like it was spun by magic. That is Westminster Abbey.

The Grave Nobody Steps On

Just inside the great west door of the abbey, in the middle of the floor where everyone walks in, there is one grave surrounded by red poppies that nobody is allowed to step on. Even a king walking to his own coronation steps around it. Inside is a soldier, and here is the strange, powerful thing. Nobody knows his name. After the First World War, a war so terrible that huge numbers of soldiers were never found or never identified, Britain chose one unknown body from the battlefields of France and brought it home in 1920. He was buried right here, among the kings, with soil carried back from the battlefields and a slab of black marble laid on top. He stands for every single soldier who died and was never found, so that every family who lost someone could look at this grave and think, maybe that's him, maybe he's finally home and honored among kings. When a royal bride gets married here, she leaves her flowers on this grave. It is the only gravestone in the whole abbey you must never walk

across.

Now for a happier corner. One part of the abbey is called Poets' Corner, because it is packed with writers. The tradition started almost by accident. A poet named Geoffrey Chaucer was buried here over six hundred years ago, mostly because he'd had a job at the abbey, not because he was a poet. But later writers wanted to be buried near him, and it slowly turned into the most famous writers' graveyard in the world. Charles Dickens is here, the man who wrote about ghosts at Christmas. So is Thomas Hardy, sort of. His body is here, but his heart was buried separately back in his home village, and there's a spooky old legend that a cat got hold of the heart first. We'll let you decide about that one.

And there are scientists too. Remember Isaac Newton, who explained why apples fall down instead of up? His grand tomb is here, and over the centuries the scientists who came after him wanted to be buried close by, as if gathering around a hero. Charles Darwin is near him, and in 2018 the ashes of Stephen Hawking, the wheelchair genius who studied black holes, were placed in the floor right between Newton and Darwin. Three of the greatest minds Britain ever produced, keeping each other company for the rest of time.

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A Square Full of Heroes

Stand in Parliament Square and slowly turn all the way around. You are surrounded by statues of giants, about a dozen of them, some of the most important people of the last few hundred years, all standing guard over this patch of grass. See how many you can spot. There's a stocky man in a long coat, leaning on a stick, looking grumpy and determined. That's Winston Churchill, Britain's leader during the Second World War, and his statue is placed so he can glare straight across at Parliament. There's a tall man with his arms flung wide open, caught in the middle of a speech. That's Nelson Mandela, who spent twenty-seven years in prison in South Africa and came out to become its president. There's a small figure in sandals and a shawl, walking with a stick. That's Mahatma Gandhi from India, who helped change the world without ever throwing a single punch. And there is one woman, holding up a cloth banner with words stitched across it. She was the very first woman ever given a statue in this square, and that only happened in 2018, after more than a hundred and fifty years of nothing but men. We'll tell you her story next. All around, people come

to this square to march, to cheer, and to protest, waving their signs right under the noses of these bronze heroes. It's a square where history is standing up on its feet, keeping watch.

The First Woman in the Square

For over a hundred and fifty years, Parliament Square was a sort of club that only let in statues of men. Prime ministers, generals, and war leaders, all of them men cast in bronze, standing on tall stone blocks. Not one woman among them. Then in 2018 that finally changed, and the woman they chose was named Millicent Fawcett.

Millicent Fawcett spent almost her whole life, more than fifty years, on one enormous task. She wanted to win women the right to vote. Back then, in Britain, only men were allowed to vote for who ran the country. Women had no say at all, no matter how clever or hard-working or wise they were. Millicent thought that was ridiculous and unfair, and she said so, calmly and stubbornly, over and over, for decade after decade. She gave speeches, she organized huge numbers of women, and she never gave up, even when people laughed at her or told her to go home and be quiet. And bit by bit, she helped win. Women finally got the vote, and Millicent lived just long enough to see it happen.

Now look at her statue. Unlike the others, she isn't posing like a soldier or sitting grandly on a horse. She's holding up a banner, a real cloth-looking banner in bronze, and stitched across it are the words, courage calls to courage everywhere. Those were her own words. She meant that when one brave person stands up, it gives courage to everyone watching them do it. The statue was made by an artist named Gillian Wearing, and here's a lovely detail. Around the bottom of the statue are the faces and names of fifty-nine other women and men who fought alongside Millicent, so that she isn't standing there all alone. She brought her friends with her. It took until 2018, far too long, but the first woman finally took her place among the giants. And fittingly, she's the one holding up a banner, reminding everyone else in the square to be brave.

Meet the Rest of the Giants

Keep turning around the square and you'll meet more heroes. There's Abraham Lincoln, the American president who ended slavery in the United States, standing here in London because Britain and America are old friends. This statue is actually a copy of a famous one in Chicago. There's Sir Robert Peel, who might just be the reason a British police officer is nicknamed a bobby. Peel started London's

first proper police force, and people began calling the new officers bobbies and peelers, after his name, Robert Peel. There's David Lloyd George, a fiery leader who ran Britain at the end of the First World War, shown mid-stride as if he's marching off to give someone a stern talking-to. And there's Benjamin Disraeli, a prime minister who was also a bestselling novelist and one of Queen Victoria's favorite people in the whole world.

Now back to Winston Churchill, the grumpy-looking man in the long coat. Pigeons love to land on statues, and, well, you can probably guess what pigeons leave behind. So the story goes that a tiny, harmless electric current runs through Churchill's head, to give any landing bird a gentle buzz and shoo it away, keeping him clean. Whether or not that's really true, look at where he's placed. He stares straight across at the Houses of Parliament, the building where he argued and led and won, as if he's still keeping a careful eye on the place even now.

And look to the west side of the square, at a grand stone building with pointy towers that is not Parliament. That's the Supreme Court, the very highest court in the whole United Kingdom. When the most difficult, most important legal argument in the country cannot be settled anywhere else, it ends up in there, decided by a small group of the most senior judges in the land. So this one square has the people who make the laws across the road in Parliament, the top judges who settle the laws over here in the court, and a dozen bronze giants watching over all of it. No wonder people come here to march and protest. If you want the whole country to hear you, you come and stand where the heroes are standing.

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The Street That Runs the Country

You're now walking down a wide street called Whitehall, and it might look like just a road with big grey stone buildings. But almost every one of these buildings is a part of the government that runs Britain. In fact, the word Whitehall is a kind of secret code. When people on the news say Whitehall decided something, they mean the government did. Inside these buildings, thousands of people are quietly running the army, the money, the schools, the whole country. Right in the middle of the road, look for a tall, plain stone monument standing all by itself. It's called the Cenotaph, and it's one of the most important objects in Britain, even though it is completely empty inside. That word, cenotaph, actually means empty tomb. We'll tell you

why an empty tomb matters so very much. Then, a little further along, look for a black iron gate with a police officer standing guard. Behind it is the most famous front door in Britain, a shiny black door with the number ten on it. That's Downing Street, where the Prime Minister, the leader of the whole country, lives and works. And living right behind that door, believe it or not, is a cat with an official government job title. His name is Larry, and he is the country's Chief Mouser. Yes, that is a genuine, real job. Let's find out more about all of it.

The Empty Tomb in the Middle of the Road

Stand and look at the tall stone monument in the center of Whitehall. It seems simple, almost plain, just a slender tower of pale stone with some carved wreaths and stone flags on it. But this is the Cenotaph, and it is one of the most loved objects in the whole country. It was built in 1920, right after the First World War, a war in which so many soldiers died far away from home that hundreds of thousands of families never got a body to bury, never had a grave to visit. So a designer named Edwin Lutyens built them this. An empty tomb, standing for every one of those missing soldiers, a place where any grieving family could come and feel close to the person they had lost. The word cenotaph literally means empty tomb.

Every year in November, on a day called Remembrance Sunday, this street fills up with silent crowds. The King, the Prime Minister, and old soldiers all come to lay wreaths of bright red poppies at the foot of the Cenotaph, and at eleven o'clock in the morning the entire nation goes quiet for two whole minutes. No talking, no traffic, nothing at all. Just silence, to remember. If you visit around that time of year, the whole base of the monument is buried under red poppy wreaths.

Here's a clever secret hidden right in the stone. The Cenotaph looks perfectly straight, with upright sides and flat, level tops. But almost none of its lines are actually straight. The sides lean very slightly inward, so gently that your eye can't see it, and if you followed those lines up into the sky they would eventually meet at a single point, high above the clouds. The flat parts aren't really flat either. They're gently curved, like tiny slices of an enormous invisible ball. Lutyens did all this on purpose, using an ancient building trick, because perfectly straight lines can look a little stiff and dead, while these secret hidden curves make the cold stone feel calm and almost alive. So this quiet grey monument, standing right in the middle of the traffic, is

empty on the inside, secretly curved on the outside, and holds more feeling packed into it than almost any building in London.

The Most Famous Front Door in Britain

Behind those black iron gates is a short, ordinary-looking street, and about halfway down it is a plain brick house with a shiny black door and the number ten painted on it. This is 10 Downing Street, and a Prime Minister has lived and worked behind that door since 1735, which is almost three hundred years. Look closely at that famous door, or at pictures of it, and you'll spot some funny secrets. The number zero in the ten is painted slightly crooked, tilted like the hand of a clock, and it's been that way so long that they carefully repaint it crooked on purpose every time. There's a letterbox that says First Lord of the Treasury, which is an old-fashioned title for the Prime Minister. And strangest of all, the door has no keyhole on the outside. You cannot open it from the street, not ever. Someone always has to open it from the inside, which means there is always somebody in there, waiting, day and night.

The big black gates across the road weren't always there. For hundreds of years, anyone could walk right up Downing Street and stroll to the door. The gates were only added in 1989, to keep the Prime Minister safe. Before that, tourists used to wander up and have their photo taken on the very doorstep.

And now the best part. Living behind that door is a cat named Larry, and he has an official job title, Chief Mouser to the Cabinet Office. His actual job is to catch mice. Larry started work in 2011, after being rescued from an animal shelter called Battersea, and he has now lived there far longer than most Prime Ministers, watching leader after leader arrive and then pack up and leave, while he simply stays put, snoozing on the warm pavement and strolling in and out of the world's most famous door whenever he pleases. Reporters camp outside Number Ten waiting for big, important news, and half the time the only celebrity who wanders out is a fat tabby cat on the hunt for a pigeon. Some people joke that Larry is the one truly in charge of the country. Keep your eyes open for him. He's often right there on the step.

The Palace That Vanished

Here's something hard to believe as you look at all these serious government offices. This whole street is named Whitehall because a gigantic royal palace once stood right here, and it has almost completely vanished into thin air.

The Palace of Whitehall was once the largest palace in all of Europe, with over one thousand five hundred rooms, bigger than the Vatican, bigger than Versailles in France. Kings and queens lived here, including Henry the Eighth, the king with six wives. It had tennis courts, a bowling green, a pit for cockfighting, and sprawling gardens running right down to the river.

So where did it all go? It burned down. In 1698 a servant was reportedly drying some laundry too close to a fire, the fire got out of control, and over the next hours the greatest palace in Europe burned to the ground. Almost nothing survived the flames. Just one single building was saved, a beautiful hall that you're about to walk past at the very next stop, called the Banqueting House. Everything else, all fifteen hundred rooms, was gone forever, and new streets and offices were slowly built on top of the ashes. So when you say the word Whitehall, you are really saying the name of a ghost, a spectacular lost palace hiding somewhere under the pavement beneath your feet.

Before you move on, look for one more quiet monument standing in the middle of Whitehall, a tall block of bronze. Walk all the way around it and you'll spot something surprising and touching. Carved into the bronze are seventeen empty sets of clothes, coats and uniforms and overalls, all hanging on pegs with nobody inside them. This is the memorial to the Women of the Second World War. During that war, while huge numbers of men were away fighting, millions of British women did every kind of job to keep the country going. They built airplanes, drove ambulances, worked the land, nursed the wounded, and even broke secret enemy codes. The empty uniforms stand for all the different jobs those women took on, hung up as if the women have just stepped out of them after a long, hard day's work. For a very long time nobody had built them a monument, and this one finally went up in 2005. Empty clothes on pegs, standing for the millions of women who quietly kept the whole country running.

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The Guards Who Must Not Move

Look for the soldiers on horseback, sitting in little stone booths, wearing shiny metal helmets with long horsehair plumes and holding gleaming swords. These are real soldiers of the King's own cavalry, called the Household Cavalry, and guarding this exact spot is a genuine job, not a show for tourists. Here's the challenge that makes crowds gather round. The guard and the horse must stay almost perfectly

still, for a long time, no matter what happens. People take selfies right beside them, wave their arms, and pull silly faces, and the guard just stares straight ahead, not moving a muscle. Even the horses are trained to stand as still as statues. It takes incredible discipline. They do change over in a little ceremony most mornings, at around eleven o'clock, and ten o'clock on Sundays, with trumpets and clapping hooves, so if you time it right you can watch them ride in. Walk through their archway and you come out into a huge open square of gravel called Horse Guards Parade. Once a year, in June, this whole square fills up with hundreds of soldiers in red coats and tall furry black hats for the King's official birthday parade. And nearby stands a rather plain but elegant old building called the Banqueting House, which hides one of the darkest, most dramatic stories in all of English history. Once, a king walked out of an upstairs window of that very building, onto a wooden stage, and had his head chopped off in front of a huge crowd. We'll tell you exactly how it happened. Ready?

The King Who Lost His Head

Here is the true and terrible story of the Banqueting House. Nearly four hundred years ago, Britain had a king named Charles the First who believed he had been chosen by God to rule, and that he should never have to share his power with anyone, not even Parliament. He argued with Parliament so badly that the whole country split into two sides and fought a long, bloody civil war, ordinary people against their own king. And the astonishing thing is, the king lost. His own people captured him, put him on trial, and decided that a king who made war on his own people was a traitor who must die.

On a freezing cold morning, the thirtieth of January, in the year 1649, Charles was led through the Banqueting House, the very building right in front of you, and out through a window onto a wooden platform built against the wall, where a huge, silent crowd was waiting. Now here is the detail that everybody remembers. It was bitterly cold that morning, and Charles was worried about something. He feared that if he shivered from the freezing air, the watching crowd might think he was shivering with fear. A king must not look afraid, he thought, even at the very end. So the story goes that he asked to wear two shirts, an extra layer underneath, just so he wouldn't shake and look like a coward. He gave a short speech, said a prayer, lay down and put his head on the block, and the executioner cut off his head with a single blow. A great groan went up from the crowd,

a sound one man who was there said he never forgot for the rest of his life.

For a few years afterward, Britain had no king at all, and was run without one. But it didn't last, and Charles's own son eventually came back and became king in his place. To this very day, Charles the First is the only king of England ever put on trial by his own people and executed. And it all happened right here, on a platform against this wall, on a cold winter morning, with a brave and stubborn king wearing two shirts so nobody would see him shiver. Look up at those windows and try to picture it.

Statues That Breathe

Standing still sounds easy, until you actually try it. The mounted soldiers here have to sit on a horse, in a heavy uniform, holding a sword, staring straight ahead, while crowds of tourists gather right up next to them. They're allowed to blink and breathe, of course, but they don't chat, they don't smile, and they don't react, even when someone is being really silly just a few centimeters from their face. It is so tiring, for both the rider and the horse, that these mounted guards get swapped for fresh ones every single hour. Standing that still really is that hard.

There's one important thing to know, so you don't get a surprise. The guards are not allowed to speak to you, and they won't move, but the horses can move, and sometimes a horse will suddenly shift its feet, stamp, or swing its huge head around. There are even polite signs asking visitors to keep back a little, because these are big, powerful animals, not fairground ponies. So you can stand close for a photo, but give the horse a bit of room and don't crowd it.

Every morning there's a proper changing ceremony, at around eleven o'clock, and ten o'clock on Sundays, when a whole fresh troop of cavalry rides down from their barracks, hooves clapping and metal jingling, to take over the guard. And there's a second, quieter parade every single afternoon at four o'clock, and this one comes with a great legend. The story goes that long ago, Queen Victoria turned up here unexpectedly and found that the guards had sneaked off and were gambling and drinking instead of doing their duty. She was so annoyed that she ordered the whole regiment to be inspected every single afternoon at four o'clock, for the next one hundred years, as a punishment. The hundred years are long over now, but, the story goes, they still line up every afternoon anyway. Whether or not every detail of that tale is exactly true, if you happen to be here at four o'clock, you can watch the daily inspection yourself and imagine a

furious young queen deciding to teach her soldiers a lesson that would last a whole century.

The Painted Ceiling and the Birthday Parade

The Banqueting House looks calm and plain from outside, all neat columns and even, tidy windows. And that is actually why it was so special. When it was built, around the year 1622, most English buildings were higgledy-piggledy, with crooked timbers and odd, uneven shapes. This one was completely different. An architect named Inigo Jones had traveled all the way to Italy and come back in love with the clean, balanced style of ancient Rome, and the Banqueting House was the first proper building of that kind in the whole of England. People thought it looked amazingly modern and perfect.

But the real treasure is hidden inside, up on the ceiling. If you ever get to go in, lie back and look straight up, because up there is one of the greatest painted ceilings in the world, made by Peter Paul Rubens, one of the most famous painters who ever lived. The huge, swirling, golden painting shows King James the First, who was the father of Charles the First, being carried up into heaven by angels and clouds, as if a king were somehow halfway to being a god. And here's the sad, strange twist you can't help thinking about. Remember that Charles the First was led right through this very hall on his way to be executed. That means, on the last walk of his whole life, King Charles passed directly underneath that glorious ceiling showing his own father soaring up to heaven like a god, before stepping out of the window to lose his head. Nobody knows for certain whether he looked up.

One more thing to picture before you go. That big square of gravel behind the guards, Horse Guards Parade, comes bursting to life once every June for a spectacular parade called Trooping the Colour, held for the King's official birthday. Hundreds of soldiers in bright red coats and tall, furry black hats march in perfect lines, bands play, drums thunder, and the royal family watches, some of them riding in gleaming golden carriages. From an ordinary, empty gravel square most of the year, to the grandest parade in the whole country for one single summer morning. If you happen to be in London in June, that is the place to be.

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The Arch, the Secret Nose, and the Red Road

Look at the enormous curved building with archways cut right through it. This is Admiralty Arch, built over a hundred years ago, in 1912, as a grand gateway. Walk through

one of its arches and everything suddenly changes. In front of you stretches a long, wide, dead-straight road, and it's a strange color, a deep reddish pink, almost like a giant red carpet made out of stone. This is called The Mall, and it leads all the way to Buckingham Palace, where the King lives. On special days, flags line the whole route and golden carriages roll slowly down it. It's the road that Britain uses for its very biggest parades and celebrations, a proper royal red carpet, half a mile long.

But before you march off down The Mall, we have a secret to share with you, and it's a little bit silly. Hidden on the inside wall of the arch, at about the height of a person riding a horse, there is a tiny sculpture of a human nose. A real little nose, sticking right out of the wall, that almost nobody ever notices. For years and years, people made up wild stories about whose nose it was and why it was there. Some said soldiers on horseback would rub it for good luck as they rode through the arch. We'll tell you the funny truth about that nose in a moment. So there are two things to hunt for at this stop. A secret nose hiding in a wall, and the reddest, most royal road in all of Britain. Off we go.

The Secret of the Nose

So, whose nose is stuck to the wall inside Admiralty Arch, and why on earth is it there? For years, nobody knew, and that is exactly how mysteries turn into legends. The most popular story people told was that the nose was put there for soldiers of the Household Cavalry to rub for good luck as they rode their horses through the arch, which is supposedly why it sits at just the right height for someone up on horseback. Others whispered that it was the nose of the Duke of Wellington, the general who beat Napoleon, or even a spare nose, kept in case the statue of Nelson up the road ever lost his own. These are all just stories, fun to tell but not actually true. Remember, when someone tells you a tale like that, it's perfectly fine to enjoy it, as long as you know it's a legend and not a fact.

Here's what really happened, and honestly it's even better than the legends. Back in 1997, an artist named Rick Buckley made a cast, a mold, of his very own nose. His actual, real nose. And then, secretly and sneakily, without asking anyone's permission, he glued little copies of it onto walls all over the middle of London. He stuck up around thirty-five of them, and he often placed them right underneath security cameras. Why would he do that? It was a kind of joke and a protest, both at once. In those years, cameras were popping up everywhere across the city, watching

people all the time, and Buckley wanted to show that he could stick something right under a camera's nose, so to speak, and nobody would even notice it was there. For years and years, nobody knew who had done it, which is exactly what made people invent all those wild legends. Eventually Buckley admitted that it had been him all along.

Most of his noses have been scrubbed off or have fallen away over the years, but a handful still survive, including this one inside Admiralty Arch, and several more hidden around a neighborhood called Soho, where people still go on hunts to find what they call the Seven Noses of Soho. So the next time a grown-up tells you the cavalry rubbed it for luck, you can tell them the real answer. It's an artist's own nose, playing a clever trick on the cameras. You know the secret now. See if you can spot it before you walk on.

The Royal Red Road

Now for The Mall itself, that long straight road glowing reddish under your feet. Why is it red? It was designed that way on purpose, to look like an enormous red carpet rolled out toward Buckingham Palace, so that royal parades would look as grand and magnificent as possible. The whole route was laid out in 1911, as part of a giant plan to honor Queen Victoria after she died, and Admiralty Arch was built as its fancy front door, connecting the busy, noisy Trafalgar Square at one end to the calm, ceremonial road at the other. Stand under the arch and look straight down The Mall, and

far away at the very end you can just make out the pale stone front of Buckingham Palace.

On really big days, the kind that only happen a few times in your whole life, this road is where Britain celebrates. Rows of flags go up all along both sides, huge crowds pack onto the pavements, and the royal family rides down the middle in golden horse-drawn carriages, waving, on their way to a coronation, or a jubilee, or a royal wedding. Afterward, everyone squeezes down The Mall to gather in front of the palace and cheer, all of them hoping the royal family will come out onto that famous balcony to wave back down at the crowd.

Keep an eye out for one more royal building tucked just off to the side of The Mall, an old red-brick palace with battlements and a clock tower, called St James's Palace. It's over five hundred years old, built by Henry the Eighth, and even though the King doesn't actually live there now, it is still officially the most senior, most important royal palace in the whole country. When a brand new king or queen is announced to the nation, it's still done from a balcony there. So this one short, straight, red road connects an arch with a secret nose hidden in it, an ancient brick palace where kings are announced, and the most famous home in all of Britain, all lined up in a single straight line. Not bad for one short walk. Enjoy The Mall.